



from the Academy, but I didn't want to go." By then, the household had established its own schedule. When he wasn't training in Surat, Harmeet was travelling to various table tennis hubs in search of quality partners and training facilities. "I must have practised at every major training facility all over India," he says. From Narkeldanga and Ultadanga in old Kolkata to the swanky gymkhana in Pune and clubs in Chennai, he would travel whenever he could.

While he trained somewhere or was taking exams in his hometown — "once the school failed me due to lack of attendance"— sometimes, Desai Sr. would travel alone to Senior National Championships, videotaping matches so that Harmeet could watch and improve

his game. **It was the pre-YouTube era, and such innovations helped Harmeet upgrade his skills.** While he has worked with various coaches during his journey, he holds Swedish legend Peter Karlsson in high regard, ever since he travelled to his academy for the first time as a 16-year-old.

"Peter once told me in Sweden that table tennis is just 10-20 per cent of life. He said there are more

important things like family or food. I didn't understand what he meant at that time. For me, table tennis was life, and my life was always about table tennis. Whether I got more or less money didn't matter. If the achievement was less or more, that didn't affect me. It was always a constant."

Since we are on a trip down memory lane, I ask him whether he recalls the first time he thought of

« Harmeet's year-long stint at PSPB as an eight-year-old convinced his parents about his passion »